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NEWSPAPER

1st JAN, 2019

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

1st WEEK



**SHEIKH HASINA FOR FOURTH TERM
... BUT CHALLENGE IS RULE OF LAW**

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

1st JANUARY, 2019



Learning **Space**

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Happy & Prosperous
New Year - 2019**

1

Hasina's triumph

After the Awami League landslide, she must repair Bangladesh's bitter political divisions

Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's party was always going to win Sunday's parliamentary election. She remains immensely popular, her government sought a fresh mandate with a formidable record of economic growth and social progress and her party, the Awami League, set the agenda for the election and dominated the campaign. Still, the scale of the victory would have taken even her supporters by surprise. The party's Grand Alliance won 288 of the 299 seats contested, more than the 234 seats it won in 2014 when the Bangladesh Nationalist Party boycotted the poll. This time, the Opposition coalition Jatiya Oikya Front, led by the BNP, secured only seven seats. But there are conflicting claims about the way the election was conducted. As soon as the results were known, Kamal Hossain, the leader of the Opposition coalition, called it a farcical election and demanded that the Election Commission call a fresh poll. More than 40 Opposition candidates pulled out of the race after voting began on Sunday, alleging rigging. However, the Election Monitoring Forum and the SAARC Human Rights Foundation, which includes both local and international observers, said in its preliminary evaluation that the election was "much freer and fairer" than previous ones. In the past, Bangladesh had seen governments declining to hold elections, one being cancelled and called again, and others being delayed amid violence. This time the election was called on time. Participation was higher, with the turnout at 66%, compared to 55% in 2014.

The challenge before Ms. Hasina is daunting. To begin with, she has to heal a country riddled by political divisions and violence. The government and the Election Commission could have held the election without being open to charges that it was manipulated. There was a crackdown on the Opposition in the run-up to polling day. Pro-Opposition websites were taken down, thousands of activists were jailed, and political violence was unleashed to target BNP members. The situation was so grave that even one of the election commissioners said there was no level playing field. The Election Commission should conduct a fair investigation into allegations of rigging to restore faith in the poll process. Ms. Hasina should reach out to the Opposition. Her otherwise impressive record has been marred by her government's authoritarian character. The victory is a chance for Ms. Hasina to mend her ways, to be more inclusive and run a government that respects the rule of law, the basic rights of citizens and institutional freedom. For India, Ms. Hasina's victory is good news. New Delhi and Dhaka have deepened economic, security and strategic ties under her leadership. This should continue, no matter what the general election outcome in India in 2019.

Agenda for the fourth term

The Sheikh Hasina government must go beyond economic progress to ensure rule of law and democracy



The people, as they say, have spoken in Bangladesh. Sheikh Hasina's party, which leads the Grand Alliance, has stepped back to power for an unprecedented fourth term in office. The general election has given the Grand Alliance, or, more specifically, the Awami League, a huge majority in the Jatiya Sangsad, the country's Parliament, at a point where so of India's Opposition is in a celebratory mood, the Jatiya Oikya Front has rejected the results and demanded fresh polls under a neutral government. Jatiya Oikya Front member Kamal Hossain, around whose personality the Opposition came together to challenge what it called the authoritarianism of the government led by Ms. Hasina, has called Sunday's vote "farcical".

The significance of this election
The political reality for Bangladesh at this juncture revolves around a couple of factors. First, for the first time in a decade, all the political parties took part in the election. The Bangladesh Nationalist Party, or the BNP, boycotted the 2014 election. In other words, this time voting was based on an inclusive election. Second, this was the first time a general election was held under a political government since the fall of the Hussain Muhammad Ershad military regime in 1990. The earlier stipulation of elections being supervised by a caretaker administration, introduced in the final stages of General Ershad's regime and carried on till the period of the Fatherland Awami-led military-backed caretaker government between January 2007 and early 2009, was scrapped in 2011 through a constitutional amendment by the Awami League government which assumed office in January 2009. Despite promises from the Opposition against the move, the Hasina government remained unmoved. It stuck to the justified position that a government elected for five years cannot morally and logically hand over power to an unelected administration for



"a country where politics has often been vulnerable to extra-constitutional interference and where national history has been massively distorted. Ms. Hasina has turned out to be the most powerful political leader in Bangladesh's story." Dhaka on polling day. —

three months before a new elected government comes into office.

This election has downed the usual criticism from the Opposition, which has alleged that candidates did not have a level playing field in the course of the campaign. Moreover, on election day, at a large number of polling centres across the country, polling agents of the Opposition were either not allowed to enter the polling stations or driven out of them by ruling party activists. Mr. Hossain and the BNP have cited these as the reasons for voting having been unfair and not free. The government has rejected the allegations. It has instead pointed to what it describes as a massive degree of popular support for Ms. Hasina and her government's development programmes.

From trauma to victory

For Ms. Hasina, politics has been a long journey from personal trauma following the assassination of nearly her entire family in a violent coup in August 1975 to her rise to political prominence in the years since she took charge of the Awami League. She has been chief of the Awami League since 1981, when she was persuaded to return home from exile in India by senior party leaders, including Mr. Hossain. Her return galvanised a factionalised party into coming together as a strong political force, a feat which resulted in her leading it to electoral victory for the first time in 23 years in June 1996. Ms.

Hasina's assumption of office as Prime Minister was certainly significant from the perspective of Bangladesh's history. One of the earliest priorities for her government was a repeal of the infamous Indemnity Ordinance, promulgated in the post-coup circumstances and subsequently accorded legal sanction by a Parliament dominated by supporters of General Ziaur Rahman, Bangladesh's first military ruler. The ordinance had blocked any questioning of the coup as well as a trial of the assassins of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and his family in any court of law. Five of the assassins were tried and executed in January 2010.

That apart, the Hasina government took steps to bring some prominent Bengali collaborators of the occupation Pakistan army in 1971 to trial. These collaborators, belonging to the Jamaat-e-Islami and the Muslim League and rehabilitated by General Zia and given ministerial berths by Khaiside Iqbal, were tried by special 32 constitutional war crimes tribunals and hanged. In effect, on Ms. Hasina's watch, the impunity which the 1975 assassins and 1971 collaborators had enjoyed was brought to an end.

Steering the economy

To be sure, there have been questions regarding the government's treatment of the Opposition in the run-up to the election — cases filed against Opposition leaders and activists, seen as an impediment to

a free functioning of the media, etc. But it is the strength of its economic performance that the government has projected before the electorate, in a point where the international community, including the World Bank, has been appreciative of the strides made in the economy. Remittances from Bangladeshis working abroad have registered a significant rise, the ready-made garment industry has been performing well, growth has gone up, and massive infrastructure projects have been undertaken. In the field of foreign affairs, the government has based its approach to the outside world on pragmatism, thus successfully preserving a balance in Bangladesh's relations with India, China and Russia. The government has also found appreciation from the international community in its treatment of the Rohingya refugees — nearly 1 million refugees have found shelter in Bangladesh following their expulsion from Myanmar. It has gone out of its way to ensure the safety of the refugees even as it tries, rather tentatively, to strike a deal with Myanmar on the return of the Rohingyas.

In a country where politics has often been vulnerable to extra-constitutional interference, as in the coups and counter-coups of the mid-1970s and the emergence of two military regimes in quick succession, and where national history has been massively distorted by those who evicted power between 1975 and 1996, Ms. Hasina has turned out to be the most powerful political leader in the country's history, after her father Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. Her three terms in office, and now a promised fourth, make her the longest-serving head of government in Bangladesh. There has been no alternative to her.

In the next five years, it will be the government's responsibility to go beyond an emphasis on economic progress to ensure rule of law and democracy, in the form of a properly functional Parliament, a free judiciary, and an efficient executive. Now that the election is behind her, Ms. Hasina looks to provide over the century of the birth of the country's founder in 2020 and the 50th anniversary celebrations of Bangladesh's independence in 2025.

Syed Badrul Alam is a journalist and columnist in Bangladesh.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

India and its neighborhood- relations.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Ensuring Rule of Law goes much beyond achieving economic growth. Examine the issue in the context of neighbouring Bangladesh.

1 Hasina's triumph

After the Awami League landslide, she must repair Bangladesh's bitter political divisions.

Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's party was always going to win Sunday's parliamentary election. She remains immensely popular, her government sought a fresh mandate with a formidable record of economic growth and social progress and her party, the Awami League, set the agenda for the election and dominated the campaign. Still, the scale of the victory would have taken even her supporters by surprise. The party's Grand Alliance won 288 of the 299 seats contested, more than the 234 seats it won in 2014 when the Bangladesh Nationalist Party boycotted the poll. This time, the Opposition coalition Jatiya Oikya Front, led by the BNP, secured only seven seats. But there are conflicting claims about the way the election was conducted. As soon as the results were known, Kamal Hossain, the leader of the Opposition coalition, called it a farcical election and demanded that the Election Commission call a fresh poll. More than 40 Opposition candidates pulled out of the race after voting began on Sunday, alleging rigging. However, the Election Monitoring Forum and the SAARC Human Rights Foundation, which includes both local and international observers, said in its preliminary evaluation that the election was "much freer and fairer" than previous ones. In the past, Bangladesh had seen governments declining to hold elections, one being cancelled and called again, and others being delayed amid violence. This time the election was called on time. Participation was higher, with the turnout at 66%, compared to 51% in 2014.

1 Hasina's triumph

The challenge before Ms. Hasina is daunting. To begin with, she has to heal a country rattled by political divisions and violence. The government and the Election Commission could have held the election without being open to charges that it was manipulated. There was a crackdown on the Opposition in the run-up to polling day. Pro-Opposition websites were taken down, thousands of activists were jailed, and political violence was unleashed to target BNP members. The situation was so grave that even one of the election commissioners said there was no level playing field. The Election Commission should conduct a fair investigation into allegations of rigging to restore faith in the poll process. Ms. Hasina should reach out to the Opposition. Her otherwise impressive record has been marred by her government's authoritarian character. The victory is a chance for Ms. Hasina to mend her ways, to be more inclusive and run a government that respects the rule of law, the basic rights of citizens and institutional freedom. For India, Ms. Hasina's victory is good news. New Delhi and Dhaka have deepened economic, security and strategic ties under her leadership. This should continue, no matter what the general election outcome in India in 2019.

1 Agenda for the fourth term

The Sheikh Hasina government must go beyond economic progress to ensure rule of law and democracy.

The people, as they say, have spoken in Bangladesh. Sheikh Hasina's party, which leads the Grand Alliance, has romped back to power for an unprecedented fourth term in office. The general election has given the Grand Alliance, or, more specifically, the Awami League, a huge majority in the Jatiyo Sangshad, the country's Parliament, to a point where no effective Opposition is in sight.

While Awami League supporters are in a celebratory mood, the Jatiya Oikya Front has rejected the results and demanded fresh polls under a neutral government. Jatiya Oikya Front convener Kamal Hossain, around whose personality the Opposition came together to challenge what it called the authoritarianism of the government led by Ms. Hasina, has called Sunday's vote "farcical".

The significance of this election

The political reality for Bangladesh at this juncture revolves around a couple of factors. First, for the first time in a decade, all the political parties took part in the election (the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, or the BNP, boycotted the 2014 election). In other words, this time voting was based on an inclusive election. Second, this was the first time a general election was held under a political government since the fall of the Hussain Muhammad Ershad military regime in 1990. The earlier stipulation of elections being supervised by a caretaker administration, introduced in the final stages of General Ershad's regime and carried on till the period of the Fakhruddin Ahmed-led military-backed caretaker government (between January 2007 and early 2009), was scrapped in 2011 through a constitutional amendment by the Awami League government which assumed office in January 2009. Despite protests from the Opposition against the move, the Hasina government remained unmoved.

1 Agenda for the fourth term

It stuck to the justified position that a government elected for five years cannot morally and logically hand over power to an unelected administration for three months before a new elected government comes into office.

This election has drawn the usual criticism from the Opposition, which has alleged that candidates did not have a level playing field in the course of the campaign. Moreover, on election day, at a large number of polling centres across the country, polling agents of the Opposition were either not allowed to enter the polling stations or driven out of them by ruling party activists. Mr. Hossain and the BNP have cited these as the reasons for voting having been unfair and not free. The government has rejected the allegations. It has instead pointed to what it describes as a massive degree of popular support for Ms. Hasina and her government's development programmes.

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1 Agenda for the fourth term

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Steering the economy

To be sure, there have been questions regarding the government's treatment of the Opposition in the run-up to the election — cases filed against Opposition leaders and activists, laws seen as an impediment to a free functioning of the media, etc. But it is the strength of its economic performance that the government has projected before the electorate, to a point where the international community, including the World Bank, has been appreciative of the strides made in the economy. Remittances from Bangladeshis working abroad have registered a significant rise, the ready-made garments industry has been performing well, growth has gone up, and massive infrastructure projects have been undertaken. In the field of foreign affairs, the government has based its approach to the outside world on pragmatism, thus successfully preserving a balance in Bangladesh's relations with India, China and Russia. The government has also found appreciation from the international community in its treatment of the Rohingya refugees — nearly 1 million refugees have found shelter in Bangladesh following their expulsion from Myanmar. It has gone out of its way to ensure the safety of the refugees even as it tries, rather fitfully, to strike a deal with Myanmar on the return of the Rohingya.

1 Agenda for the fourth term

In a country where politics has often been vulnerable to extra-constitutional interference, as in the coups and counter-coups of the mid-1970s followed by the emergence of two military regimes in quick succession, and where national history has been massively distorted by those who exercised power between 1975 and 1996, Ms. Hasina has turned out to be the most powerful political leader in the country's history, after her father Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. Her three terms in office, and now a promised fourth, make her the longest-serving head of government in Bangladesh. There has been no alternative to her.

In the next five years, it will be the government's responsibility to go beyond an emphasis on economic progress to ensure rule of law and democracy, in the form of a properly functional Parliament, a free judiciary, and an efficient executive. Now that the election is behind her, Ms. Hasina looks to preside over the centenary of the birth of the country's founder in 2020 and the 50th anniversary celebrations of Bangladesh's independence in 2021.

Syed Badrul Ahsan is a journalist and columnist in Bangladesh

PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF BANGLADESH



SHEIKH HASINA

Prime Minister, Bangladesh

The foreign policy is based on pragmatism, it maintains balance in relations with India, China and Russia. It also got appreciation for its response for around one million Rohingya refugees.

- ✓ **Formed in 1971** (prior to that, it was known as East Pakistan)
- ✓ Fertile alluvial plains are created by **Padma, Meghna & Jamuna** rivers.
- ✓ Southern Coast is **Sundarbans mangrove forest**, home to Royal Bengal Tiger.
- ✓ Official **Language is Bengali**.
- ✓ Much of Bangladesh is vulnerable for flooding.
- ✓ Ferries are important form of transport.

Country	Bangladesh
Capital	Dhaka
Currency	Bangladeshi Taka
Population	160 million (approx.)
National Anthem	Amar Sonar Bangla written by Rabindranath Tagore



West Bengal	2,216.7
Tripura	856
Meghalaya	443
Mizoram	318
Assam	263
TOTAL	4096.7

5 The present Govt. led by Sheikh Hasina of Awami League is maintaining cordial relations with India and Bangladesh is one of the very few bright spots for India, when we look at the economic influence of China on our neighbouring countries.

4 Bangladesh is cooperating in terrorist related investigations and because of its support, North-eastern region is peaceful as far as insurgency is concerned.



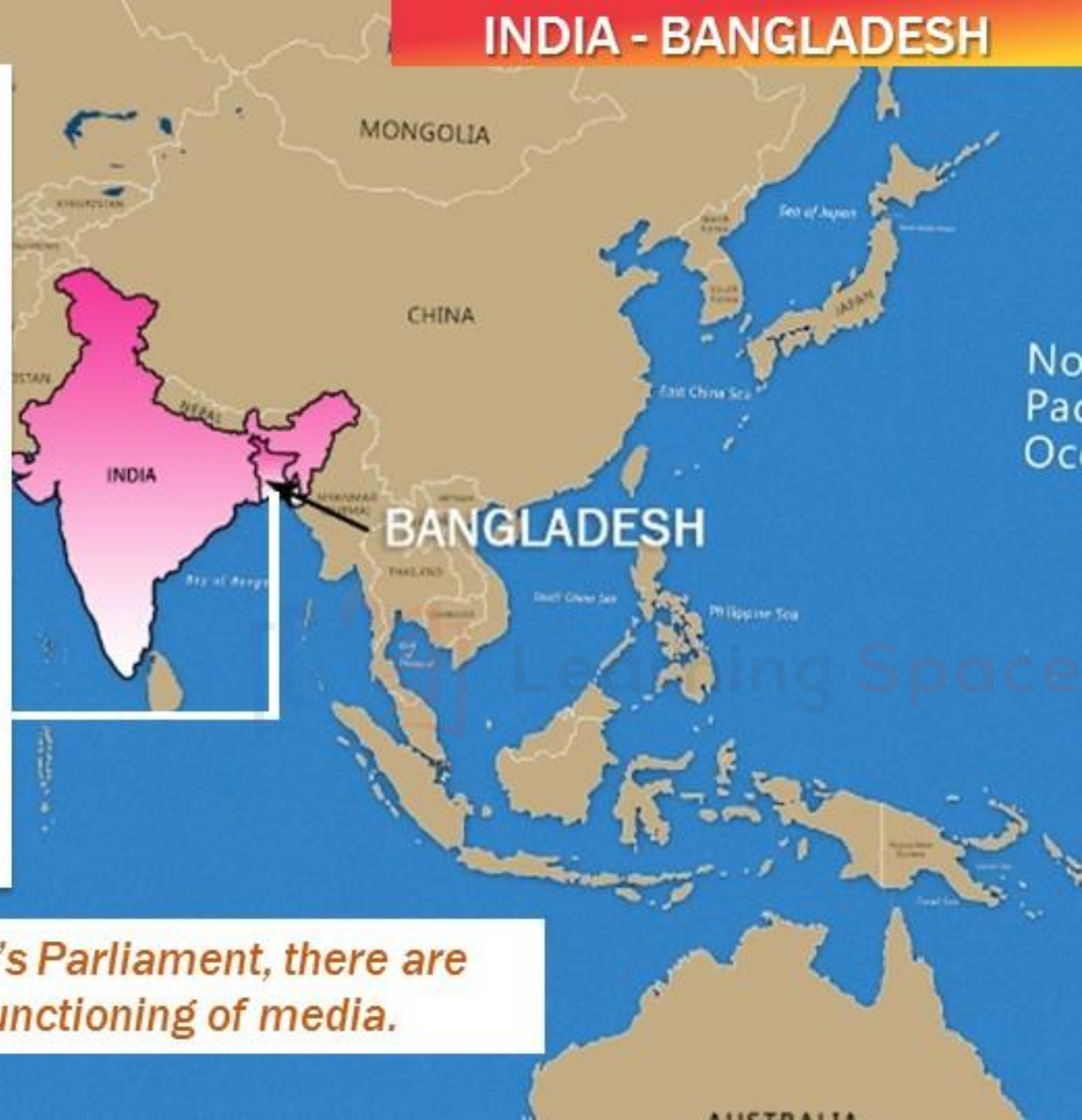
1 Land mark agreement on transfer of enclaves between India and Bangladesh, which facilitated transfer of several enclaves between the two countries.

2 Agartala – Akhaura rail link (15 kms) will come up. Cost to be entirely borne by India.

3 Extension of railway line from Agartala to Sabroom and construction of bridge over Feni river, so as to access Chittagong port.

INDIA - BANGLADESH

- The party's Grand Alliance won 288 of the 299 seats contested.
- It won 234 seats in 2014, when BNP boycotted the poll.
- Now, the Opposition Coalition Jatiya Oikya Front, led by BNP, secured only seven seats, but opposition called it a farcical election.
- More than 40 Opposition candidates pulled out of the race, after voting began alleging rigging.
- But, the Election Monitoring Forum and the SAARC Human Rights Foundation, which includes local and international observers, said the election was much freer and fairer than the previous ones.



Jatiya Sangsad is the country's Parliament, there are impediments to the free functioning of media.

AUTHORITARIAN CHARACTER OF SHEIKH HASINA



- 1 Before elections, there was crackdown on the Opposition.
- 2 Pro-Opposition websites were taken down, thousands of activists were jailed.
- 3 One of the Election Commissioners said, there was no level playing field.

The Election Commission should conduct a free investigation into allegations of rigging to restore faith in poll process.

WAY FORWARD FOR SHEIKH HASINA!

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4 That is possible, if Parliament functions properly with free judiciary and efficient executive.

3 It goes much beyond economic progress to ensure rule of law and democracy.

ONE MORE TERM

1 She has to heal the Country rattled by political divisions and violence.



2 She should be more inclusive and run a Government that respects the rule of law, basic rights of citizens and institutional freedom.

When Sheikh Hasina looks to preside over the Centenary of the birth of country's founder in 2020 and the 50th anniversary celebrations of Bangladesh Independence in 2021, the moral responsibility is on Sheikh Hasina.

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SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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